‘take over the chairmanship for a couple of years and then pass it on to Ratan’. Much later, replying to my question of whether JRD had requested Mody to take over TELCO, Ratan said, ‘Both yes and no.’ But there was little doubt that JRD preferred Mody over everyone else.

Mody was JRD’s favourite. He was chosen to not only take over TELCO but also perhaps as chairman, Tata Sons, when JRD would step down. As Ratan elaborated to journalist Vir Sanghvi: ‘In fact, for most of the 1980s, I personally thought that Rusi [sic] was certain to be the next head of [the] Tatas. He ran Tata Steel very successfully, had a larger-than-life personality and Jeh [JRD] was very fond of him. I think Jeh liked him because he had many of the qualities that Jeh would have liked to have had himself. Rusi was gregarious. He was outgoing. He could go into a crowd of workers and charm them.’

JRD made no secret of his admiration for Mody. In an interview after he stepped down from the Tata Sons’ chairmanship in 1991, he lauded Mody’s exceptional talent, saying: ‘In fifty years, not a day has been lost due to labour trouble. Russi Mody and TISCO created a new relationship between industry, management and labour, a unique culture that did not exist in the old days.’ Notwithstanding JRD’s admiration, Mody’s claim that he had been chosen to be the TELCO chairman during a meeting with the Tata Sons chairman and Ratan in early 1988 at the Tata Training Centre on an island in Dimna Lake, near Jamshedpur, was far-fetched.

Nevertheless, if the appointment as TELCO chairman had gone through, it would have placed Mody in an unassailable position to stake claim to the post of chairman, Tata Sons, when such a vacancy arose. Even JRD may have found it difficult to restrain Mody because he would have been, by then, at the helm of the two largest Tata Group companies.

However, JRD’s admiration for Mody did not mean that he had side-lined Ratan. He had assured the latter that no important decision concerning the group would be taken without his knowledge.

In the meantime, the news that Mody was likely to take over as chairman, TELCO, reached Nani Palkhivala, the deputy chairman. The fellow Parsi did not take kindly to the news. It was the tradition in Tata companies for the deputy chairman to take over as chairman when the position became vacant. Following this practice, Russi Mody and Darbari Seth had succeeded JRD in TISCO and Tata Chemicals, respectively. It led to a